MINUTES OF THE CLARE COUNTY BOARD OF COMMISSIONERS

Approved 1-21-2026

225 W. Main St.
Harrison, Michigan 48625

~~Unapproved~~ minutes
December 17, 2025

Meeting was called to order at 9:00 a.m.

Pledge of Allegiance to the Flag of the United States of America

District 1 Marlene Housler, District 2 Dale Majewski, District 4 Jeff Haskell, District 5 David Hoefling, District 6 Jack Kleinhardt, District 7 Gabe Ambrozaitis and District 8 George Gilmore

COMMISSIONERS ABSENT

District 3 Jacob Gross and District 9 Rick Fancon

OTHERS PRESENT

Clerk & Register of Deeds Lori Mott, Administrator Lori Phelps, Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger, Deputy Clerk Isha Walter, members of the public and zoom participants

APPROVAL OF AGENDA

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to approve the agenda, **Motion carried.**

APPROVAL OF MINUTES

It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the amended Board of Commissioners Minutes of November 12, 2025, **Motion carried**.
*Changes: Remove Administrator Lori Phelps and Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger from the Others Present section

GENERAL PUBLIC COMMENT

None

COMMUNICATIONS LIST

1. Letter to Attorneys for Audit – No Discussion
2. Letter from Village of Farwell notification of Master Plan draft – No Discussion

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT

Administrator Lori Phelps reported that the annual audit is currently underway. The State Treasury has taken an alternative approach with an expanded review. She also informed the Board that 94 computers were replaced during the recent computer replacement project, all computers are now up to date with the required programs. She recognized Josh Chapman, Information Technology (IT) Director for his outstanding work during the project.

Administrator Phelps will be opening the Fiscal Year 2027 budget at the end of December and she has begun the bidding process for health insurance. A new Title 4D funding policy requires all employees to read and acknowledge the policies and entered into their personnel files annually. At the State level, the House approved work projects cuts totaling $645 million in Fiscal Year 2025. Additionally, Administrator Phelps informed the Commissioners that she prepared Lake Level books for each of them and she will keep them updated.

ADMINISTRATOR'S REPORT - continued

Lastly, Administrator Phelps gave a few department updates. Veterans Services, with assistance from the Sheriff's Department, distributed more than a dozen holiday baskets. Throughout 2025, more than 265 veterans were provided with transportation assistance to medical appointments. The animal shelter is at capacity and is currently seeking high protein dog food. Senior Services has added a second daily meal and carryout meals are still available. The final update was in regards to the Vice Chair position. Per statute, the Vice Chair is required to be elected annually for a one year term so this will be included on the next agenda.

PUBLIC HEARINGS/SPECIAL PRESENTATIONS

1. Region VII Area Agency on Aging
   Dayna Altom, newly appointed Chief Executive Officer of Region VII Area Agency on Aging introduced herself to the Board of Commissioners. She gave a brief update on how the agency supports the senior citizens of Clare County, highlighting the partnership with Clare County Senior Services.

JUSTICE

None

HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICES

1. Department of Health and Human Services
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to reappoint Eileen Couchman to the Department of Health and Human Services Board for a three-year term, **Motion carried**.

PHYSICAL RESOURCES AND ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

None

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION

1. Statutory Finance Committee
   It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Statutory Finance Committee meeting minutes of November 10, 2025 in the amount of $139,321.24, meeting minutes of November 24, 2025 in the amount of $277,745.09 and minutes of December 8, 2025 in the amount of $35,414.32, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Gilmore, Ambrozaitis, Haskell, Hoefling, Kleinhardt, Housler and Majewski
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Gross
   Motion carried.

2. Monthly Expenditures
   It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the expenditures for the month of November 2025, in the amount of $1,870,589.55 with the General Fund expenditures totaling $1,360,980.88, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Majewski, Kleinhardt, Housler, Hoefling, Haskell, Gilmore and Ambrozaitis
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Gross
   Motion carried.

FINANCE AND ADMINISTRATION - continued

3. Budget Adjustments
   It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve Budget Adjustments 26-12, 26-13, 26-14, 26-16, 26-18 and 26-21 in the amount of $279,676, $112,805, $121,108, $115,500, $172,375 and $694,000 respectively, roll call vote revealed:

   Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Haskell, Kleinhardt, Majewski, Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Hoefling and Housler
   Nays: (0)
   Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Gross
   Motion carried.

4. Policy and Procedures
   a. Fund Balance Policy Discussion
      After some discussion between the Board of Commissioners, Administrator Phelps and Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger,
      It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to up the Fund Balance to 40%, roll call vote revealed:
      Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Hoefling, Gilmore, Ambrozaitis, Majewski, Kleinhardt, Haskell and Housler
      Nays: (0)
      Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Gross
      Motion carried.

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Haskell, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the Injury Reporting Policy and the Procedure for Reporting Workplace Injuries as presented, **Motion carried.**

   c. It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve the updated Non-Union Personnel Policy Manual as presented, **Motion carried.**

   d. It was moved by Commissioner Hoefling, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the Marijuana and Alcohol Use Policy as presented, **Motion carried.**

5. Board of Commissioners Meeting Dates
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to approve the Board of Commissioners meeting dates through December 2026 with dates consistent with the third Wednesday of the month unless specified on the posting with meeting to begin at 9:00 a.m., **Motion carried.**

   b. It was moved by Commissioner Housler, seconded by Commissioner Haskell to approve the Finance meeting dates as presented through December 2026 starting at 9:00 a.m. with dates consistent with the off week of payroll, **Motion carried.**

6. Holidays
   a. It was moved by Commissioner Kleinhardt, seconded by Commissioner Housler to approve the Holiday Schedule as presented for calendar year 2026, **Motion carried.**

CLERK/REGISTER OF DEEDS REPORT

Clerk and Register of Deeds Lori Mott reminded the Board of Commissioners of the property fraud alert service offered to all Clare County residents. There is a current ongoing investigation of property fraud in our county confirming that making Clare County residents aware of the free service is beneficial. Clerk and Register of Deeds Mott confirmed that work is already underway for 2026 elections and confirmed the filing deadline for proposals for the August 2026 ballot. Clerk and Register of Deeds Mott also informed the Board that the changes made by Judge Ambrozaitis and Judge Hovey will result in her office staff calling 2,000 less jurors in 2026. She shared that at her last conference recently a lobbyist spoke about the Ax MI Tax initiative and they are confident it will not pass. Lastly, she reported on cost saving measures taken by her office.

TREASURER'S REPORT

Treasurer Jenny Beemer-Fritzinger provided all the statutory reports to the Commissioners. She reminded the Commissioners that because she was absent from the November meeting she emailed them the November statutory reports. Winter tax collection along with disbursements will be happening soon. The fifty drains and six lake levels on the winter tax rolls will be challenging, the dog license deadline is February 28, 2026, and Treasurer Beemer-Fritzinger mentioned that there will be a one stop shop rabies clinic at the Animal shelter in February 2026. Lastly, she stated that, as Clerk Mott mentioned, her office also takes cost saving measures.

CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Chairman George Gilmore expressed his surprise regarding Grant Township's recent significant increase for liability insurance. He suggested other townships get new estimates.

VICE CHAIRMAN'S REPORT

Absent

COMMISSIONER'S REPORT

Commissioner Hoefling gave a brief report on each of the townships and committees he represents.

Commissioner Ambrozaitis gave an update on the Clare County Airport.

Commissioner Housler had no report.

Commissioner Kleinhardt updated the Board regarding a request from DTE to construct a solar energy alternative park in Arthur Township.

Commissioner Haskell had no report.

Commissioner Gross was absent.

Commissioner Majewski had no report.

STATE OF THE COUNTY BUDGET

No Discussion

PUBLIC COMMENT

Clare County Road Commission Manager Dewayne Rogers gave a report on the work being completed throughout Clare County. He also highlighted the 2025 Winter Newsletter which was created by a Career and Technical Education (CTE) student. Lastly, Michigan Works awarded a Road Commission employee the Clare County Alumni of the Year award, the Clare County Road Commission won Employer of the Year, along with the State Impact Award for Employer of the Year. They will be accepting the award in April 2026 in Lansing.

UNFINISHED BUSINESS

None

NEW BUSINESS

It was moved by Commissioner Majewski, seconded by Commissioner Ambrozaitis to approve Friday, December 26, 2025 as an additional holiday for 2025, **Motion carried.**

CLOSED SESSION

It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Hoefling to go into closed session under section 8(h) of the Open Meetings Act to discuss our attorney's written opinion, roll call vote revealed:

Yeas: (7) being Commissioners Ambrozaitis, Gilmore, Haskell, Hoefling, Housler, Kleinhardt and Majewski
Nays: (0)
Absent: (2) being Commissioners Fancon and Gross
Motion carried.

Entered into closed session at 10:10 a.m.
Back in open session at 10:53 a.m.

ADJOURNMENT

It was moved by Commissioner Ambrozaitis, seconded by Commissioner Majewski to adjourn, **motion carried.**

Meeting adjourned at 10:54 a.m.

Lori Mott, Clerk
Clare County Board of Commissioners

George Gilmore, Chairman
Clare County Board of Commissioners